

VOCATIONAL REHABILITATION STATE PROFILE

Oklahoma

How Oklahoma VR Partners with Higher Education Programs for Students with Intellectual Disability

By Julie Lackey and Melinda Fruendt

Vocational Rehabilitation (VR) is a critical partner in supporting students with intellectual disability to access higher education, sometimes referred to as inclusive postsecondary education (IPSE). Through collaboration, VR and higher education programs can increase access, opportunities, and success for college students with intellectual disability. Building strong VR partnerships can be challenging for some programs. In this resource, we share how Oklahoma's state VR agency has successfully partnered with Oklahoma's state higher education programs for students with intellectual disability.

Current State of Higher Education Partnerships

Oklahoma's state VR agency has active contracts with all four higher education programs for students with intellectual disability operating in the state. Three programs are certificate programs for students with intellectual disability and one is a degree-seeking program for students with autism. For certificate programs, the contracts allow our agency – the Oklahoma Department of Rehabilitation Services – to provide up to \$3,000 per semester to students who are VR clients and who qualify under the Oklahoma VR income guidelines to offset their program costs. In addition, we offer internship wage reimbursement at minimum wage for up to 15 hours per week during school semesters to students who are VR clients. The internships are geared toward students' employment goals, which coincide with

their Individual Plan for Employment (IPE) with VR. Internships need to relate to the student's interests and strengths. Internships are great for students who want to try out a job and have the option to change direction if it is not a good fit. In addition, by earning income, the students get hands-on experience with budgeting and financial management.

Strategies Used to Implement or Improve Higher Education Partnerships

We listen to our clients and develop ways to help meet the needs they bring to us. For instance, soon after the first Oklahoma higher education program began, they approached Oklahoma VR to discuss how we could be a valuable partner to assist students. The executive team met with Julie, founder of a nonprofit called LeadLearnLive,

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who was working to begin higher education programs for students with intellectual disability in Oklahoma. She gave an overview of what was happening regarding these programs in Oklahoma and **brought in experts from other states** to talk about partnerships between VR and programs. We learned from Think College that students with intellectual disability who complete PSE programs **show strong employment outcomes** (see [Think College's TPSID Annual Reports](#)), so we decided to **pilot a contract** with the first program in Oklahoma. It went so well, we now have a standard contract in place with other higher education programs and can modify that contract to work with each college or university as needed.

Innovative Practices Implemented by Oklahoma to Support Higher Education Programs

The [Oklahoma Inclusive Postsecondary Education \(OKIPSE\) Alliance](#) is a unique partnership between the Oklahoma State Department of Rehabilitation Services (DRS), Sooner SUCCESS, and the Oklahoma State Department of Education. These entities have joined together to provide financial support for the director position at the OKIPSE Alliance and are active partners in the Alliance's efforts. The OKIPSE Alliance works to connect leadership from higher education programs for students with intellectual disability, state agencies, advocacy groups, and others connected with students with intellectual disability to stay informed about higher education programs. In addition, the Alliance aims to educate and advocate throughout the state with legislators, families, and others as well as work with other institutes of higher education to begin new programs. OKIPSE Alliance's website hosts a wealth of resources intended to provide information to prospective and current students and other invested parties.

OKIPSE Alliance Director Julie Lackey shared:

"I meet with the Alliance leadership, the executive director of Oklahoma DRS, and the executive director of Sooner SUCCESS monthly or more so we are always working together on a variety of efforts to further the IPSE movement. We have found that keeping each other well informed gives us more ideas and more ways to help students and families as well as each other's organizations. It really is a true partnership."

The OKIPSE Alliance recently partnered with Oklahoma DRS and Sooner SUCCESS to host a dual-state summit highlighting Oklahoma and Texas programs. The Alliance presented to interested legislators about higher education for students with intellectual disability.

In addition, the OKIPSE Alliance and Oklahoma DRS recently partnered to begin a unique employment support pilot program in conjunction with pre-employment transition services and the Central Oklahoma Workforce Innovation Board (COWIB) to provide employer training and support for college students as they gain employment in the community. COWIB is the lead agency for the IPSE Next pilot project. The pilot came about through OKIPSE Alliance connections and brainstorming additional ways to support students working in the community both while in higher education programs and after graduation. For more information on this project, contact Julie Lackey from the OKIPSE Alliance by email at julie@okipsealliance.org.

Advice for Effective Collaboration Between VR and Higher Education Programs

- » **Begin Together.** One way to get started is to develop a pilot program together. Programs and VR must be open to making changes internally and together to determine what works best. Budget is a driving factor for any VR agency, and we do not have enough resources to meet all the needs we are

presented with. In addition, every state has different guidelines, so although it seems like one state should be able to do what another state does, sometimes it takes time to explore approaches.

- » **Gather Information from Other States.** VR personnel can make the time to listen and gather information. Find out what other states have done, and work on collaborating and developing a relationship to facilitate communication.
- » **Start with One Partner.** Higher education program staff can start by building a relationship with at least one VR partner. Work together to answer questions and address challenges. This relationship will help you develop a better understanding of your state VR agency and enhance collaboration.
- » **Communication is Key.** The bottom line is that there needs to be good communication with key people within programs and VR. It works well to have a point person who can help facilitate partnerships and communication as inclusive higher education programs grow in a state.

For more VR state profiles and resources on building collaborative relationships between higher education programs and VR, visit [Think College's Vocational Rehabilitation Resource page](#) and [Think College Network's Employment Partnerships page](#).

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